

Human health

DIET, EXERCISE, AND AVOIDING DANGEROUS SUBSTANCES HELP TO MAINTAIN A HEALTHY BODY.

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◀ 32–33 Feeding

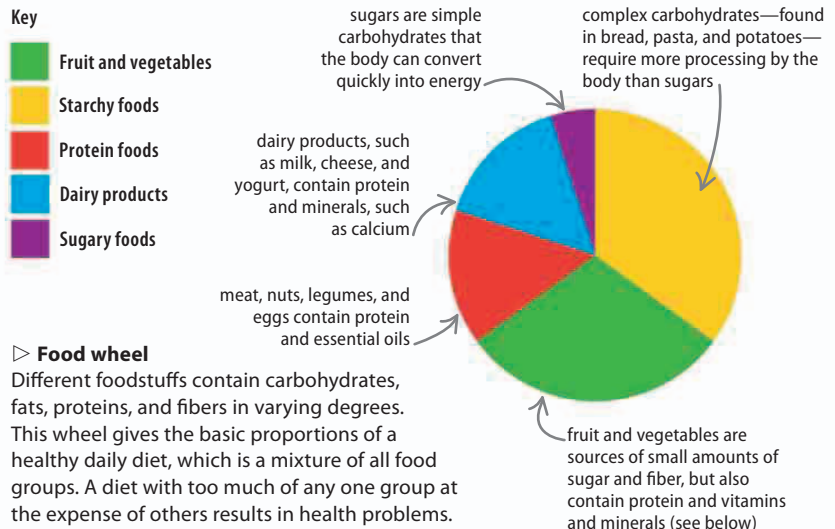
◀ 62–63 Body systems

◀ 66–67 Human digestion

Medical science and improved living conditions have resulted in human life expectancies being twice, if not three times, those of prehistoric people. However, some aspects of a modern lifestyle are at odds with maintaining a healthy body.

Healthy eating

Food is made up of four groups of substances: carbohydrates, fats, proteins, and fiber. All four are essential for a nutritious diet. Carbohydrates are found in simple form in sugary food and in complex form in starchy food. Fiber is an indigestible form of carbohydrate that keeps the digestive tract healthy. Fats and oils are concentrated energy stores, and too much of them can lead to weight problems. Finally, protein, needed for muscles and digestion, is mainly found in animal-based foods, such as meat and dairy products, but is also found in beans, chickpeas, and lentils.



Vitamins and minerals

A healthy diet contains a series of nutrients called vitamins. These are chemicals the body cannot make itself, which are essential for important metabolic processes. The health problems that vitamin deficiencies produce can usually be reversed by eating a balanced diet. The body also requires a supply of minerals, which are metals that are important for maintenance.

▷ Required nutrients

Humans require the following vitamins and minerals in small amounts in their diets.

Name	Beneficial for	Sources	Deficiency results in
vitamin A	good eyesight	liver, carrots, green vegetables	night blindness
vitamin B1	healthy nerves and muscles	eggs, red meat, and cereal	loss of appetite
vitamin B2	healthy skin and nails	milk, cheese, and fish	itchy eyes
vitamin B6	healthy skin and digestion	fish, bananas, and beans	inflamed skin
vitamin B12	healthy blood and nerves	shellfish, poultry, and milk	fatigue
vitamin C	healthy immune system	citrus fruits, kiwi, and fruits	scurvy
vitamin D	strong bones and teeth	sunlight and oily fish	rickets
vitamin E	removing toxins	nuts, green vegetables	weakness
folic acid	red blood cell formation	carrots, yeast	anemia
calcium	strong bones and healthy muscles	dairy products	bad teeth
iron	healthy blood and body cells	red meat and cereals	anemia
magnesium	healthy bones	nuts and green vegetables	insomnia
zinc	normal growth and immune system	meat and fish	growth retardation